Ancient Indian History: Stone Age & Chalcolithic Age

Comprehensive Study & Revision Notes (Civil Services / State PCS Exam Focus)

1. Historical Classification & Chronology

- **Prehistoric Period (प्रागैतिहासिक काल):** The era for which no written historical records exist. Human life is understood entirely through material archaeological remains (e.g., Stone Age).
- **Protohistoric Period (आद्य-ऐतिहासिक काल):** The period for which written scripts/inscriptions exist, but remain undeciphered or ambiguous (e.g., Indus Valley Civilization, Chalcolithic cultures like Ahar and Jorwe).
- **Historic Period (ऐतिहासिक काल):** Begins when written, decipherable records become available (starting around the 6th century BCE with the Second Urbanization and Mahajanapadas).

2. Broad Division of the Stone Age (पाषाण काल)

Classified based on technological advancements and types of stone tools utilized:

Period	Estimated Chronology	Core Characteristics & Tool Industry
Paleolithic Age (Old Stone Age)	~2,000,000 BCE to 10,000 BCE	Hunting and food-gathering; unaware of fire usage (ate raw meat); no animal husbandry or agriculture.
Mesolithic Age (Middle Stone Age)	~10,000 BCE to 7,000 / 6,000 BCE	Microliths (miniature stone tools); advent of animal domestication; rock art.
Neolithic Age (New Stone Age)	~7,000 BCE to 1,000 BCE	Systematic food production (agriculture), domestication, pottery, sedentary living, pit dwellings.

Three Phases of the Paleolithic Age:

- **Lower / Early Paleolithic:** Dominated by core tools—Hand-axes, Choppers, Cleavers. The *Chopper-Chopping Pebble culture* was discovered in the Sohan River Valley (Punjab, Pakistan).
- **Middle Paleolithic:** Dominated by flake tools. Hence termed **"Flake Culture"** or *"Flake-Blade-Scraper Culture"*. Tools were primarily fashioned from quartzite stones.
- **Upper Paleolithic:** Characterized by blade and burin tool kits. Notable find: **Bone mother goddess figurine (मातृदेवी की प्रतिमा)** discovered at Lohanda Nala in the Belan Valley (Prayagraj, UP), currently housed in the G.R. Sharma Memorial Museum at the University of Allahabad.

Key Pioneers & Archaeological Expeditions:

- **1863: Robert Bruce Foote** (British geologist and archaeologist from the Geological Survey of India - GSI) discovered India's first Paleolithic stone tool (a hand-axe) at **Pallavaram** near Chennai. Soon after, his colleague William King discovered Acheulian tools at Attirampakkam (Madras Hand-Axe Tradition).
- **1935:** The Yale-Cambridge Expedition led by **H. de Terra and T.T. Paterson** carried out extensive investigations in the Sohan Valley.
- **Belan Valley (UP):** Excavated under the guidance of **Prof. G.R. Sharma** (University of Allahabad), revealing 44 Paleolithic sites documenting a continuous stratigraphic sequence.

3. Mesolithic Age (मध्य पाषाण काल)

- **Discovery of Rock Art:** In 1867–68, **Archibald Campbell Carlleyle** discovered the first rock paintings in India at Sohagighat (Kaimur Hills, Mirzapur, UP).
- **Bhimbetka (Raisen, MP):** The premier site of prehistoric rock art, with over 500 painted rock shelters depicting hunting and communal life. Inscribed on the UNESCO World Heritage list.
- **Earliest Human Skeletal Remains:** Human osteological remains in India appear for the first time during the Mesolithic period:
  - **Langhnaj (Gujarat):** Microliths, animal bones, graves, and 14 human skeletons.
  - **Mahadaha (Pratapgarh, UP):** Large quantities of bone and antler artifacts and ornaments. Divided into lake area, butchery area, and cemetery-cum-habitation area.
  - **Damdama (Pratapgarh, UP):** 41 human burials excavated, including 5 double/twin burials and 1 triple burial (48 total skeletons).
  - **Sarai Nahar Rai (Pratapgarh, UP):** Shallow rectangular graves inside the habitation area; one joint burial containing 4 individuals.
  - **Lekhahia (Vindhyan Region, UP):** Rock shelter 1 yielded 17 human skeletons; John R. Lukacs (University of Oregon) identified remains of 27 distinct individuals.
- **Origins of Animal Husbandry:** Domestication evidence begins during the transitional terminal phase of the Mesolithic at:
  - **Adamgarh** (Narmadapuram, Madhya Pradesh)
  - **Bagor** (Bhilwara on Kothari river, Rajasthan)

4. Neolithic Age (नवपाषाण काल)

- **Earliest Agricultural Sites:**
  - **Lahuradewa (Sant Kabir Nagar, UP):** Identified as the earliest site of agriculture in South Asia, with rice/paddy cultivation dating back to ~8000–7000 BCE.

- **Mehrgarh (Balochistan, Pakistan):** Previously regarded as the oldest site; yielded wheat cultivation dating back to ~7000 BCE and represents continuity from Neolithic to Harappan.
- **Koldihwa (Prayagraj, Belan Valley, UP):** Evidence of rice husks embedded in potsherds dating to ~6500 BCE.
- *Global counterparts:* Yangtze River Valley, China (~7000 BCE for rice) and Mexico (~6000 BCE for maize).

- **Burzahom (Kashmir):** Famous for subterranean **pit-dwellings** and the unique practice of burying a **domestic dog alongside its master** in human graves (discovered in 1935 by De Terra and Paterson).
- **Gufkral (Kashmir):** Meaning "cave of the potter" (कुलाल); yielded early evidence of agriculture and animal husbandry.
- **Chirand (Saran, Bihar):** Prolific bone tool industry made predominantly of **antler horns**.
- **Ash Mounds (राख के टीले) in South India:** Accumulations of vitrified cattle dung associated with seasonal pastoral camps. Prominent sites include **Sanganakallu** (Ballari, Karnataka), **Piklihal**, and **Utnur**.

5. Chalcolithic Age (ताम्रपाषाण काल - Copper-Stone Era)

Copper was the first metal manipulated and utilized by humans, coexisting alongside stone tools.

- **Ahar-Banas Culture (Southeastern Rajasthan):**
  - Key sites: Ahar, Balathal, Ojiyana, Gilund.
  - Ahar was anciently designated **Tambavati** ("place having copper").
  - Gilund yielded traces of mud buildings as well as burnt-brick structures and copper fragments. Characterized by *Black-and-Red Ware (BRW)* painted with white linear designs.
- **Malwa and Kayatha Cultures (Madhya Pradesh):**
  - **Kayatha:** Junior contemporary of Harappa; one house cache revealed 28 copper bangles and 2 unique axes, along with necklaces of steatite and carnelian beads.
  - **Malwa:** Noted for its ceramic excellence (distinctive buff-slipped pottery with painted designs).
  - **Navdatoli (Khargone, MP):** Excavated by H.D. Sankalia, S.B. Deo, and Z.D. Ansari; circular and rectangular hut patterns, multi-grain evidence.
  - **Gungeria (Madhya Pradesh):** The largest prehistoric copper hoard in India, yielding **424 copper implements/weapons and 102 thin silver plates**.
- **Jorwe Culture (Maharashtra):**
  - Key sites: Inamgaon, Daimabad, Nevasa, Chandoli, Songaon, Nasik (Pravara/Godavari basin).
  - **Daimabad:** Largest known Jorwe settlement.
  - **Inamgaon:** Heavily fortified settlement protected by a deep moat; over 100 houses identified. Artisans resided on the western edge while a central 5-roomed structure represented the chieftain's dwelling.

- **Burial Customs:** Adults and children were buried within urns beneath house floors in a *North-to-South alignment*. Children frequently wore necklaces made of copper beads.

• **Foundational Institutional Milestones:**

- **Ganeshwar (Sikar, Rajasthan):** Located close to the Khetri copper belt; served as a major copper manufacturing and supply hub.
- **Eastern Regional Sites:** Chirand, Senuwar, Sonpur, Taradih (Bihar); Pandu Rajar Dhibi and Mangalkot/Mahishdal (West Bengal).
- **Archaeological Survey of India (ASI):** Alexander Cunningham appointed first Archaeological Surveyor in 1861 ("Father of Indian Archaeology"); institutionalized as a department in 1871; reorganized under Lord Curzon in 1901; John Marshall appointed Director-General in 1902.
- **Three-Age System (Stone, Bronze, Iron):** Classified in 1836 by **Christian Jürgensen Thomsen** based on artifacts in the National Museum of Denmark (Copenhagen).